

Non-Paper: Serbia – UAE Polling Station

Serbian citizens in the Middle East left without a polling station for the parliamentary elections of 25 October 2026

Summary. The Republic Electoral Commission of the Republic of Serbia, acting on the proposal of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, has not designated a polling station in the United Arab Emirates for the parliamentary elections of 25 October 2026 – the first time since the Embassy of the Republic of Serbia in the UAE was established in 2013. More than 800 voters registered to vote in the UAE, several times the statutory minimum. As the UAE polling station would have been the only one in the Middle East, Serbian citizens across the region are left without a polling station.

1. Facts

For the first time since its establishment in 2013, the Embassy of the Republic of Serbia in the United Arab Emirates will not host a polling station for the upcoming parliamentary elections.

The Republic Electoral Commission (REC), acting on the proposal of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Serbia (MFA), has not designated a polling station in the United Arab Emirates for the parliamentary elections to be held on 25 October 2026.

According to 2022 estimates by the Government of the Republic of Serbia, more than 10,000 citizens of the Republic of Serbia live and work in the United Arab Emirates.¹

According to unofficial information available, more than 800 registered voters have expressed their intention to vote in the United Arab Emirates. On 4 October 2026, citizens received confirmation from the Embassy of the Republic of Serbia in the UAE that their intention to vote abroad in the upcoming elections had been recorded. Nevertheless, no polling station has been designated in the UAE.

The polling station in the United Arab Emirates would have been the only polling station in the Middle East. Its absence therefore extends beyond the interests of the Serbian community in the UAE alone and affects a large number of citizens of the Republic of Serbia living and working throughout the region.

2. Legal framework

Article 57 of the Law on the Election of Members of Parliament (*Official Gazette of the Republic of Serbia*, No. 14/2022, as amended), which governs the designation of polling stations abroad, provides that a polling station abroad shall, where possible, be designated for no fewer than 100 and no more than 2,500 voters.² According to the information available, the number of citizens registered to vote in the UAE exceeds this statutory minimum several times over.

Article 52 of the Constitution of the Republic of Serbia guarantees the right to vote to every adult citizen of the Republic of Serbia who meets the conditions prescribed by law, while the electoral legislation of the Republic of Serbia provides for the exercise of this right at the voter's place of residence abroad.

3. Voting history in the United Arab Emirates

Year	Registered voters	Remarks
2014	97	Polling station designated
2020	—	Voting not held due to the COVID-19 pandemic
2022	329	Polling station designated
2023	447	Polling station designated
2026	800+ (unofficial)	No polling station designated

The number of registered voters in the UAE has grown steadily. Compared with 2014, when 97 voters were registered, the number of citizens wishing to vote in 2026 has increased more than eightfold. Yet precisely at the moment when citizens' interest in exercising their right to vote has reached its highest level, no polling station has been opened.

4. Citizens' response

In less than 24 hours, citizens submitted more than 150 individual objections to the Republic Electoral Commission, requesting that Serbian citizens living in the UAE be enabled to exercise their right to vote through the opening of a polling station.

5. Request

Citizens of the Republic of Serbia residing in the United Arab Emirates call on all competent institutions to reconsider this decision and to enable Serbian citizens living and working in the UAE and the wider region to exercise their right to vote.

As the Republic of Serbia is a candidate country for membership of the European Union, equal access to the right to vote for citizens abroad is a matter relevant to the fundamentals of the accession process. Members of the European Parliament are respectfully invited to take note of this situation and, where they consider it appropriate, to raise it with the competent authorities of the Republic of Serbia, with a view to the designation of a polling station in the UAE before 25 October 2026.

Sources

¹ Government of the Republic of Serbia, 20 January 2022 – according to estimates, more than 10,000 Serbian citizens live and work in the United Arab Emirates.

<https://www.srbija.gov.rs/vest/en/183829/intensifying-cooperation-between-serbia-uae-in-field-of-employment.php>

² Article 57 of the Law on the Election of Members of Parliament of the Republic of Serbia – designation of polling stations abroad. https://www.parlament.gov.rs/upload/archive/files/lat/pdf/predlozi_zakona/2022/86-22%20-%20Lat..pdf

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